

ORAKZAI AGENCY

“One territory, many communities, and a changing relationship with the state.”

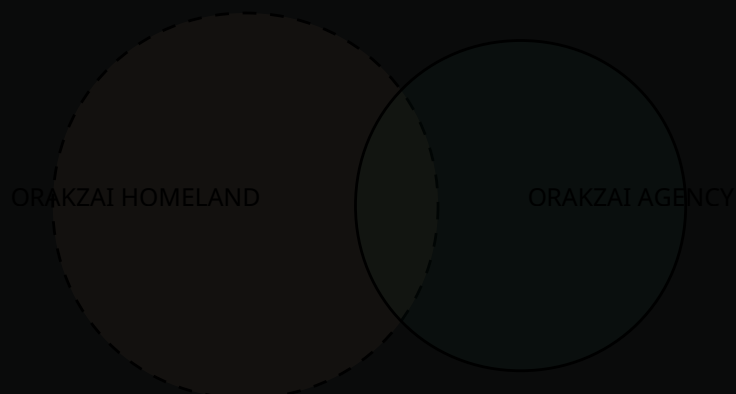
Orakzai Agency was not simply a line drawn on a map. It was an administrative framework placed over a landscape already shaped by communities, valleys, migration, trade, memory, and tribal relationships. For generations, people living in the Orakzai region encountered different forms of authority: family, tribal institutions, elders, jirga, religious leadership, political administration, and eventually the wider institutions of the Pakistani state. The Agency system became one layer within that history. Understanding it requires looking beyond the administrative name. What was the Agency? Who governed it? How was it connected to FATA? How did ordinary people experience its institutions? And what changed when the Agency became a district?



“Orakzai Agency: An administrative layer over a historical landscape.”

WHAT WAS ORAKZAI AGENCY?

Orakzai Agency was a former political agency of the ****Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA)****. The Constitution of Pakistan historically listed Orakzai among the federally administered territories, placing it under the executive authority of the President through the Governor of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. It was an administrative unit, not a sovereign state, and its primary purpose was to manage the frontier through a system of indirect rule.^{1 8}



“Identity and settlement extend beyond administrative lines.”

“The conceptual distinction between the historical homeland and the administrative agency.”

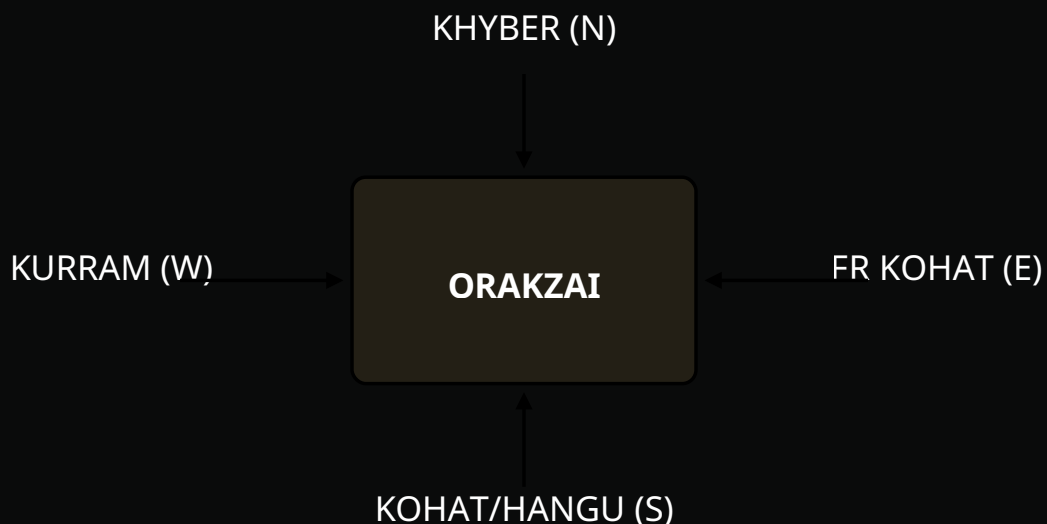
ESTABLISHMENT DATE REQUIRES SOURCE COMPARISON

Historical records provide slightly different dates for the Agency's formal creation:

- **November 3, 1973:** The President of Pakistan announced the creation of the Agency.
- **November 30, 1973:** Official establishment date cited in some administrative archives.
- **December 1, 1973:** Formal inauguration and commencement of independent functioning.

The difference reflects the gap between political announcement and institutional implementation.

Orakzai's geography defined its administrative experience. Unlike most FATA agencies, Orakzai was ****landlocked****, sharing no direct international boundary with Afghanistan. It was bounded by Khyber to the north, Kurram to the west, Kohat and Hangu to the south, and FR Kohat to the east. This meant that while it was part of the frontier, its trade and movement were mediated through its neighbors, making it a highland sanctuary within the wider tribal landscape.^{4 6}



“Orakzai's landlocked position within the regional geography.”

The ****Political Agent (PA)**** was the executive and judicial head of the Agency. Historically based in Hangu due to the lack of a suitable administrative center within the Agency's rugged interior during the early years, the PA managed the region through the ****Frontier Crimes**

Regulation (FCR)**. The system relied on **Maliks**—government-recognized tribal intermediaries—who served as the primary link between the state and the local communities.⁸



“The historical administrative hierarchy of Orakzai Agency.”

2017 CENSUS SNAPSHOT

The 2017 Census provided a statistical snapshot of Orakzai Agency just before its transition to a district. It documented a purely rural population of over a quarter-million people, living in approximately 31,000 households across the Agency’s two main sub-divisions.⁴

TOTAL POPULATION 254,303	AREA (KM²) 1,538
URBAN POPULATION 0	HOUSEHOLDS 31,420

THE 2018 TRANSITION

The constitutional status of Orakzai changed fundamentally in **May 2018** with the **25th Amendment**. The Agency framework was abolished, and Orakzai was merged into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa as a **District**. This transition replaced the Political Agent with a **Deputy Commissioner (DC)** and extended the jurisdiction of regular provincial courts and police to the region.^{2 6}

ORAKZAI AGENCY
Political Agent / FCR

25th AMEND.

ORAKZAI DISTRICT
Deputy Commissioner / Courts

“The constitutional transition from Agency to District.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Orakzai Agency was not simply a name; it was a layer of state authority over a pre-existing tribal landscape. Geography as destiny shaped Orakzai's unique trade and political relationships, as its landlocked position required a different kind of diplomacy than its border-facing neighbors. While the names have changed—from Frontier Region to Agency to District—the kinship networks and cultural identity of the Orakzai people remain the core of the region. The challenge of the modern era is to ensure that administrative integration serves the people, transforming the historical frontier into a center of opportunity and service.

“ADMINISTRATIVE LINES CHANGE. THE HOMELAND REMAINS.”

ORAKZAI AGENCY HISTORICAL ANALYSIS

